

Nonnegative and positive factorizations

Connectedness of minimal positive semidefinite factorization orbits

Difficulty: challenging **Importance:** interesting to the community

Status: Open

Rating rationale: Challenging because topology of optimal PSD factorizations must be controlled beyond size two; community importance concerns nonuniqueness and separated solution families in constrained factorization algorithms.

Area: geometry of constrained matrix factorizations

Context and notation

Write $\mathbb{S}_+^k$ for the cone of real symmetric positive semidefinite $k \times k$ matrices. For an entrywise nonnegative matrix $M \in \mathbb{R}_+^{p \times q}$, its **real positive semidefinite rank** is

$$\text{rank}_{\text{psd}}(M) = \min\{k \geq 1 : \exists A_1, \dots, A_p, B_1, \dots, B_q \in \mathbb{S}_+^k, \quad M_{ij} = \text{tr}(A_i B_j) \text{ for all } i, j\}.$$

This definition concerns a family of matrix factors indexed by the rows and columns of M .

Problem statement

Let $k \geq 3$ and $p, q \geq 1$ be integers. Suppose $M \in \mathbb{R}_+^{p \times q}$ satisfies

$$\text{rank}(M) = \frac{k(k+1)}{2}, \quad \text{rank}_{\text{psd}}(M) = k.$$

Let $\mathcal{F}_k(M)$ be the set of all tuples $(A_1, \dots, A_p, B_1, \dots, B_q)$ in $(\mathbb{S}_+^k)^{p+q}$ satisfying $\text{tr}(A_i B_j) = M_{ij}$ for every i, j . Give it the Euclidean subspace topology. Identify tuples under the changes of basis

$$A_i \mapsto S^T A_i S, \quad B_j \mapsto S^{-1} B_j S^{-T}, \quad S \in GL(k, \mathbb{R}).$$

Give the resulting orbit space the quotient topology.

Question

Is $\mathcal{F}_k(M)/GL(k, \mathbb{R})$ connected for every M satisfying these hypotheses?

The ordinary-rank hypothesis is part of the problem. The case $k = 2$ is known to be connected. The question asks whether optimal factors can belong to separated families after changes of basis are identified.

References

Fawzi, Gouveia, Parrilo, Robinson, and Thomas, *Positive semidefinite rank*, §9.2, Problem 9.4. Richard Z. Robinson, *The Positive Semidefinite Rank of Matrices and Polytopes*, University of Washington dissertation (2015), Chapter 7, especially Proposition 7.0.8.

Status check — 2026-09-10

Rechecked Fawzi et al., §9.2, Problem 9.4, including the ordinary-rank hypothesis, and searched for connectedness of PSD factorization orbits. No resolution for k at least three was located. The proved $k=2$ case is excluded here; disconnected nonnegative factorizations do not automatically remain disconnected in the PSD orbit space. No recent primary reaffirmation of the exact higher-size question was found.